

are doctors. In 2007, the figure was only six. A number of B-schools—from the MBA programme at the Management Development Institute Gurgaon, to IIM Ahmedabad's executive programme—indicate that students feel there is merit and need for an MBBS-MBA combination degree. These days, recruiters are actively scouting B-schools, looking to hire such people for the healthcare industry. While these numbers may pale in comparison to fields such as investment banking, they hold their own against the "it" sectors like real estate and telecommunications. Says Krishnakumar Sankaranarayanan, managing consultant at PricewaterhouseCoopers: "With hospitals getting corporatised and run as for-profit centres, doctors need to understand business." Adds

business from the Indian Institute of Foreign Trade) and chartered financial analyst, was recruited by Infosys Technologies as a business analyst.

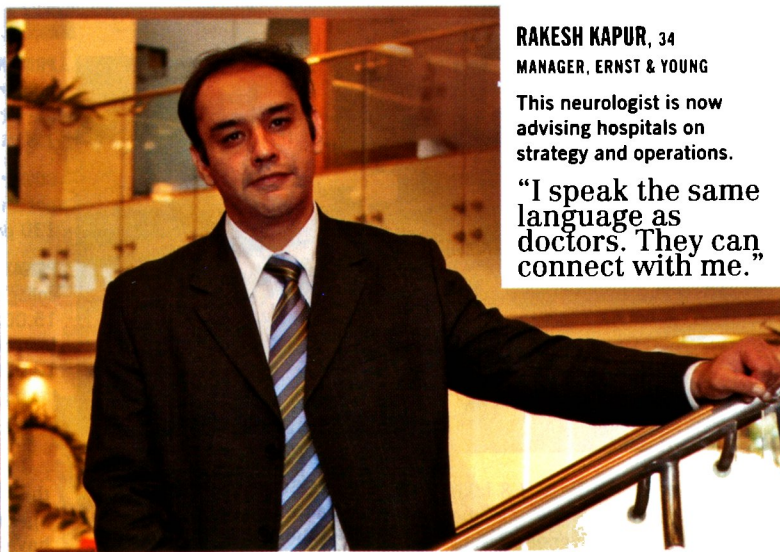
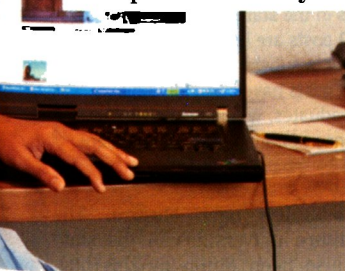
For many others, it is a sense of disillusionment with the hard work involved and the commensurate returns. Take Pinaki Sensarma, a 37-year-old doctor from Kolkata, who is doing an MBA from the Indira Gandhi National Open University. He says, "Gone are the days when one could do with just an MBBS. Today you need to do a post graduation and the number of applicants for an MD are at least 6-7 times higher than available seats. Also, one has to read 22 subjects for the entrance exam." Sensarma says he attempted an MD exam 2-3 times, till a friend recommended an MBA. "Here, I just had to study English, maths and

sured patients to the rising cost of prescription drugs. Indeed, the biggest challenge for the healthcare industry today is the acute shortage of trained staff—from doctors and nurses to administrators. Many graduate business students and recent alumni say they are up to the challenge of reforming the system—and excited about it. "Being in healthcare today is like being in the tech boom of the late 1990s," says Dr Javed Sipahi, a neurosurgeon who is at present working with Glenmark Pharma in Mumbai in sales. To cash in on this boom, schools like ISB are running active healthcare clubs, which are regularly attended by industry people. Incidentally, the school's oldest student is a 50-year-old gynaecologist, Dr Radhika Vasanthakumar, who has given up a 20-year-old practice to study busi-

BIJU MOHANDAS, 31
INDIA BUSINESS MANAGER,
ACUMEN FUND

From sitting in a clinic he is now investing in healthcare.

"I would rather get involved in health management, than see patients daily."



RAKESH KAPUR, 34
MANAGER, ERNST & YOUNG

This neurologist is now advising hospitals on strategy and operations.

"I speak the same language as doctors. They can connect with me."

Utkarsh Palnitkar, partner, E&Y: "It aligns well with the kind of services we provide. Hospital feasibility studies, public-private partnerships in healthcare all require domain knowledge, but have to be coupled with functional expertise that involves preparing financial models, econometric analysis etc." So, if Dr Kiran Shete, a 31-year-old orthopedic surgeon from Ganpatiwadi village of Maharashtra, found his calling in a strategy development role in an upcoming healthcare project by the Rs 1,000-crore Indu Projects Group, Dr Keerthi Kumar, an MBA (in international

update my general knowledge."

Whatever the reason, the booming healthcare industry affords plenty of opportunities. A PwC-E&Y study shows that organised healthcare is growing at 30 per cent annually and will see investments of up to Rs 2,22,000 crore over the next six years. That's not all. The growth of managed healthcare poses more than a few challenges for today's managers—the biggest being how to increase operational and financial efficiency. With their background, these professionals can contribute to resolving everything from the number of unin-

ness, wants to join a development organisation and work in policy making.

Of course, convincing parents and peers was an uphill task. "You are wasting your life, people told me," says Mohandas. Ashima Sarkar, an ayurvedic doctor, too faced resistance when she decided to switch careers. "I didn't think I had much to lose," says Sarkar, who is now a pre-sales manager with Firstsource, a BPO firm. "If I could make it to a good B-school, my career would be set. If not, I could always go back to my practice." Guess who is having the last laugh. ■